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Syntagmatic Structures and the Construction of the Self

Chandler's ideas on syntagmatic analysis in *Semiotics for Beginners* redefines meaning as a product of structured relations among signs, emphasizing that communication occurs through organized groups of signs, as Saussure notes.¹ This shift marks a transformation in structuralist thought: meaning emerges from systems of combination governed by convention rather than from individual signs. Chandler writes that syntagmatic relations reveal the conventions or "rules of combination" that underlie "the production and interpretation of texts."² The text's main argument is that the arrangement of elements, not the elements themselves, is most significant. Chandler emphasizes that syntagmatic structure should not be reduced to narrative sequence alone. While narrative depends on "sequential (and causal) relationships," he also identifies spatial relations based on "juxtaposition" and conceptual relations found in "exposition or argument."³

This is especially clear in film studies, where meaning is constructed across multiple levels, including frames, shots, scenes, and sequences, each defined through temporal and spatial organization.⁴ The distinction between synchronic and diachronic relations, as well as syntopic and diatopic structures, demonstrates that meaning depends on how time and space are organized.⁵ A single shot "frozen in time" (synchronic/syntopic) presents a unified moment, while a sequence unfolding over time (diachronic/syntopic) creates narrative progression.⁶ Similarly, juxtaposing different spaces (synchronic/diatopic) or connecting events across time and place (diachronic/diatopic) generates meaning through comparison and thematic association rather than through chronological continuity.⁷ Such distinctions indicate that there is no singular, stable "language" of film; instead, meaning comes from variable structural configurations.⁸ I use film here as Chandler's clearest example of syntagmatic structure, but my main concern is not cinema itself; it is how similar rules of arrangement shape my

¹ Saussure, quoted in Daniel Chandler, "Syntagmatic Analysis," in *Semiotics for Beginners*, 1.

² Chandler, "Syntagmatic Analysis," 1.

³ Chandler, "Syntagmatic Analysis," 1.

⁴ Chandler, "Syntagmatic Analysis," 10.

⁵ Hodge and Tripp, quoted in Chandler, "Syntagmatic Analysis," 11.

⁶ Hodge and Tripp, quoted in Chandler, "Syntagmatic Analysis," 11.

⁷ Hodge and Tripp, quoted in Chandler, "Syntagmatic Analysis," 11.

⁸ Chandler, "Syntagmatic Analysis," 11.

career-facing identity. Extending this insight, my central claim is that my career-facing identity is created syntagmatically: not as an inner essence expressed outwardly, but as a series of actions, achievements, comparisons, and explanations arranged into a narrative of progress. In this response paper, I apply syntagmatic analysis to examine how I construct the professional version of myself as coherent, productive, and evolving, while also considering what this structure excludes from my broader sense of identity.

The absence of a fixed cinematic language mirrors the reading's broader critique of textual logic and closure. Academic structures often create an illusion of completeness, where "stylistic seamlessness, unity and coherence are expected," and the impression is that "the matter is closed."⁹ Such closure shapes interpretation, suppresses ambiguity, and presents constructed arrangements as natural. Chandler's claim that representation is always "tidier than reality" matters because it reveals that coherence is produced, not simply found.¹⁰ Texts persuade partly by hiding their own seams, exclusions, and unresolved questions.¹¹ Thus, structure both organizes meaning and hides the choices that enable coherence. I find it unsettling that this same demand for coherence shapes my self-presentation.

This realization became clearest when I reflected on my daily routines. My activities, which include classes, assignments, internships, and job applications, function much like discrete shots in a film: individually, they do not necessarily signify "progress" or "success"; they can be viewed as isolated actions. I reflected on this recently when I received a job offer for an internship that I hope will lead to a full-time position after graduation. The offer does not exist in isolation for me; I immediately place it within a wider sequence of project drafts, portfolio work, UX design experience, and professional connections. Even searching for opportunities through the Loisa Center, if the internship does not lead to a job, it becomes part of the same sequence. I am not only accumulating experience; I am learning to organize it so that potential employers and colleagues can recognize my value. A project draft becomes portfolio evidence, a conversation becomes a connection, and a skill becomes part of my professional identity. This process has increased my confidence in expressing myself as I transition from college to the adult, career-driven world after graduation, but it also shows how identity becomes understood through arrangement. In this way, I do not simply act; I structure my various actions into a form that can be interpreted as my identity.

⁹ Chandler, "Syntagmatic Analysis," 2.

¹⁰ Chandler, "Syntagmatic Analysis," 3.

¹¹ Chandler, "Syntagmatic Analysis," 3.

I mainly structure experiences diachronically, emphasizing continuity and progress. Chandler explains that narrative syntagms are based on “sequential (and causal) relationships,” which helps me see why each accomplishment seems to prepare for the next rather than stand alone.¹² Each class, project, internship, or professional connection becomes part of a sequence that makes my life appear coherent. This approach gives my life structure, but it also imposes a logic: my life must show progress. At the same time, I compare myself to others’ internships, jobs, and advancement. Chandler’s distinction between syntagms organized through time and space is useful here, especially his categories of synchronic/diatopic and diachronic/diatopic relations.¹³ These comparisons are like juxtaposed frames: not sequential, but contrasting, considering what others have achieved, where they work, how quickly they advance, and how my position compares.¹⁴ In both cases, my sense of self comes not from isolated experiences, but from how those experiences are situated within broader structures of development and comparison.¹⁵

The reading’s analysis of syntagmatic conventions in expository writing reinforces my main argument. Chandler notes that academic writing emphasizes clarity and closure through structured topics, transitions, and conclusions.¹⁶ What matters is that this clarity mirrors my approach to life, organizing experiences to minimize ambiguity. By smoothing contradictions or eliminating loose ends, I present a coherent identity.¹⁷ My challenge, then, is not to avoid structure but to notice when a single “masculine” narrative of linearity and order overdominates the way I construct meaning.¹⁸

If syntagmatic structures are conventional, then their coherence is contingent on the rules of combination that a culture, discipline, or medium has learned to treat as natural. Chandler writes that syntagmatic relations reveal the conventions or “rules of combination” that underlie “the production and interpretation of texts,” and that using one syntagmatic structure rather than another “influences meaning.”¹⁹ In my personal narrative, improvement, productivity, and progression depend on internalized rules of combination. These rules determine what is meaningful, what fits the sequence, and what must be excluded. Classes, internships, projects, and achievements serve as evidence of progress and fit easily in the narrative. In contrast, unpredictability, uncertainty, stagnation, contradiction, and avoidance disturb

¹² Chandler, “Syntagmatic Analysis,” 1.

¹³ Hodge and Tripp, quoted in Chandler, “Syntagmatic Analysis,” 11.

¹⁴ Chandler, “Syntagmatic Analysis,” 1.

¹⁵ Chandler, “Syntagmatic Analysis,” 1.

¹⁶ Kaplan and Ostler, quoted in Chandler, “Syntagmatic Analysis,” 2.

¹⁷ Chandler, “Syntagmatic Analysis,” 2.

¹⁸ Chandler, “Syntagmatic Analysis,” 2.

¹⁹ Chandler, “Syntagmatic Analysis,” 1.

the appearance of progress and are harder to include. They seem like interruptions, not meaningful parts of life, in the story I try to make coherent. Chandler's discussion of expository writing helps explain this exclusion, since he notes that formal writing tends to have fewer visible "loose ends" and that such loose ends are often treated as "out of place."²⁰ Thus, identity is produced by structures; I recognize myself by arranging my life to fit a form that prescribes what a successful self should resemble.

Returning to Chandler's critical framework, I begin to examine how coherence in my own life is constructed rather than simply appearing. Classes, internships, deadlines, and future plans are not false or unimportant; they are real structures that organize my narrative of progress. The problem is that they can become the dominant lens through which all other experiences are judged and overshadow other aspects of my life. Chandler's attention to "structural leaks, seams and scaffolding" and to "what has been denied, hidden or excluded" helps me ask not only how my life becomes coherent, but also what that coherence requires me to leave out.²¹

Ultimately, syntagmatic analysis shows that both texts and lives are structured in ways that create meaning and impose limits. There is no intrinsic organization of experience; rather, multiple possible arrangements exist, each with distinct implications.²² Recognizing this does not mean abandoning structure, since identity, like language, relies on some organization. However, it allows questioning the pursuit of flawless coherence. Here, freedom is being less constrained by a single structure that makes my life seem like only progress. For me, this means resisting the urge to equate achievement with advancement. Other aspects of my identity that I try to avoid directly addressing in my narrative include uncertainty, rest, contradiction, and unfinishedness, which may not mark failures of meaning but instead show that my life cannot be reduced to one ordered sequence. Rather than cast myself as a perfectly coherent text, I may need to accept that meaning emerges from structures that stay open to rearrangement, interruption, and varied interpretations.

²⁰ Chandler, "Syntagmatic Analysis," 2.

²¹ Chandler, "Syntagmatic Analysis," 3.

²² Chandler, "Syntagmatic Analysis," 1.

Works Cited

Chandler, Daniel. *Semiotics for Beginners*. 1994, www.aber.ac.uk/media/Documents/S4B/semiotic.html.

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Grammarly was also used to polish this response paper.